3

THE ISI'S BOYS

Jammu and Kashmir [hereafter Kashmir] was one of 565 'princely states' given the option of accession to India or Pakistan as Partition approached. The decision was to be based on the religious composition of their populations and contiguity to one of the two new countries. The Hindu Maharaja of Kashmir, Sir Hari Singh Indar Mahindar Bahadur ruled over a state whose population was approximately three-quarters Muslim and this created expectations that it would become part of Pakistan. However, the provisions made by the British for accession did not require the rulers of the princely states to consult their respective populations.[1] Further, the British demarcated the boundaries of the two new countries in such a way that Kashmir was contiguous to both India and Pakistan. Controversy surrounds the question of whether the British Viceroy at the time of Partition, Lord Mountbatten, influenced the head of the boundary commission to alter the final border in order to connect India to Kashmir via a land route. Many Pakistanis believe he did and that this was intended to queer the pitch in India's favor so that it might secure the accession of Kashmir. Nevertheless, it was still up to Hari Sing to determine which nation the princely state would join. Instead both Pakistan and India came into being on 14 August 1947 without the Maharaja making a decision. Soon Muslims in the Kashmir district of Poonch were calling for accession to Pakistan and a heavy-handed response by Hari Sing catalyzed a rebellion. Poonchis had strong geographical, economic and religious links to parts of Pakistan, which contributed to their initial demands for accession. Now they began crossing into the new country to prepare for armed rebellion back home. This practice continued in later years, as subsequent generations of Kashmiris made a similar trip. So too did the Pakistani policy of deploying proxies, which began not long after Partition